DOTSET · PRODUCT DESIGN PROGRAM

Learn product design from zero.

A 24-week, hands-on course. You start with your first Figma file. You finish with real projects you can explain, defend and show.



24	6	5	~20h
weeks	projects, one each sprint	designers per cohort	a week

READ THIS IF YOU ARE NEW

No design background needed.

You do need time, curiosity, and the willingness to hear "this isn't good enough yet". This guide answers the questions most beginners ask before joining.

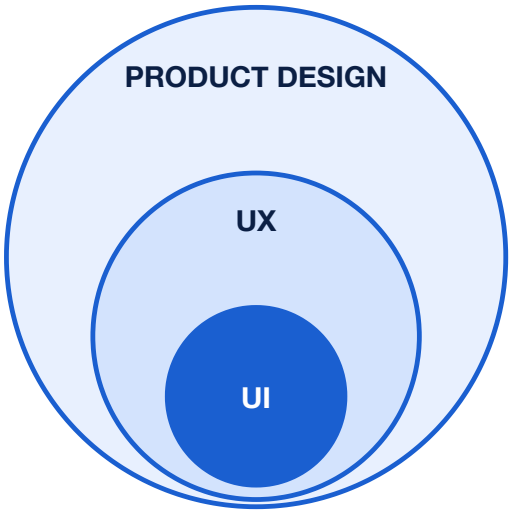
1. **Why does this course exist?**
   What goes wrong for most beginners, and how we fix it
2. **Does it matter right now?**
   What companies ask for in 2026
3. **What will I learn?**
   The tools and the ideas, in plain words
4. **How does it run?**
   The six sprints and a normal week
5. **Where can it take me?**
   Roles, what you leave with, and what we can't promise
6. **Is it right for me?**
   Who should join, and who should wait

YOUR 24 WEEKS AT A GLANCE

Visual craft	Research	Interaction	Systems	Capstone	Portfolio
wk 1–4	wk 5–8	wk 9–12	wk 13–16	wk 17–20	wk 21–24

First, what is product design?

People say UI, UX and product design like they mean the same thing. They don't. A product designer works on all three.



- **UI (the look and feel)**
  Type, colour, spacing, buttons. Does it look and feel right?
- **UX (how it works for people)**
  Research, flows, error messages. Can a real person get it done?
- **Product design (the whole thing)**
  Is this the right thing to build, and how will we know it worked?

Where most beginners get stuck

- They watch lots of videos and still can't design a real screen.
- They make pretty apps with no reasons behind them.
- Their portfolio is practice work that nobody believes.
- They freeze when someone asks, "*why did you do it this way?*"

This course is built to fix exactly those four things.

Five reasons it works differently

1. **Learn it, then use it the same day**
   Every day has a reading block, then a task built on exactly what you read. No guessing.
2. **Real, messy briefs**
   A public recruitment website, a scheme where people quit sign-up, a subscription app. Not "design a food app".
3. **Small group, honest feedback**
   Five designers per cohort. Weekly critique. Outside reviewers who don't know you.
4. **You explain your work out loud**
   Every sprint ends with a defense. You answer questions without your files open.
5. **Taught the way the job is done today**
   Accessibility rules that are now law, design tokens that designers and developers share, and AI tools used honestly. Not a 2018 syllabus.

2 · WHY IT MATTERS RIGHT NOW

Design jobs have changed.

Four shifts decide what companies ask juniors for today. Each one is built into the course.

SHIFT 1

Accessibility is now a legal issue

WCAG 2.2 is the current standard. In the EU, the European Accessibility Act has applied since June 2025.

We teach: a real accessibility check on every project, with a screen reader, not just a checklist.

SHIFT 2

Tricky design is being regulated

India's consumer protection authority published rules in 2023 naming "dark patterns", like fake countdown timers and hidden cancel buttons.

We teach: you build one on purpose, count the harm, then learn to refuse it properly.

SHIFT 3

Design and code are moving closer

Teams share "design tokens" that both designers and developers read. Figma, Storybook and browser tools are part of the job.

We teach: build a token set and a component library, then hand it over like an engineer would expect.

SHIFT 4

AI is in the product and the workflow

Companies ask two things: can you use AI tools without trusting them blindly, and can you design a feature that is sometimes wrong?

We teach: five short AI labs. You log every use and check every answer.

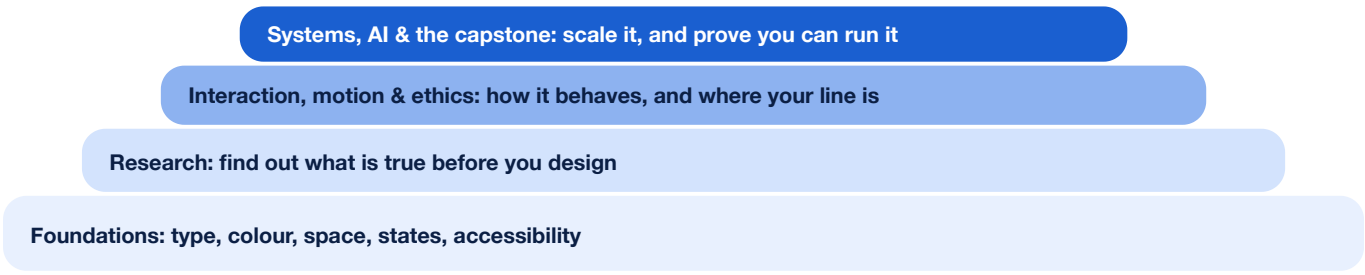
🛠️ Tools you will actually use

Figma · FigJam · Figma Dev Mode · Storybook · Style Dictionary · Tokens Studio · Maze / Lyssna · axe DevTools · VoiceOver · NVDA · TalkBack · Browser DevTools · Git & GitHub · Claude / ChatGPT / Gemini · Figma Make

💡 Ideas you will understand

Visual hierarchy · Type & colour systems · Gestalt · Cognitive load · Usability heuristics · WCAG 2.2 · Interviewing · Usability testing · State machines · Motion principles · Funnels & activation · Persuasion vs manipulation · Design tokens · Component APIs · Trust in AI

How the skills stack up



Each sprint sits on the one before it. That is why the order matters.

3 · WHAT YOU WILL LEARN

24 weeks, 6 sprints, 6 projects.

A sprint is four weeks. Each one has its own project, its own skills, and a defense at the end.



1 WEEKS 1–4

Visual craft & accessibility

Project: Kerala PSC, apply for a post

- Type, spacing and colour, with reasons
- Forms, error messages, every screen state
- Accessibility with a real screen reader

You build: one full flow, in Malayalam and English, tested with real people.

2 WEEKS 5–8

UX research

Project: a skill scheme where 38% quit sign-up

- Plan research that can prove you wrong
- Interviews and usability tests
- Findings with honest confidence levels

You build: evidence you can defend, with five real participants.

3 WEEKS 9–12

Interaction, motion & ethics

Project: Sutra, a language-learning subscription app

- State machines, feedback, motion with a purpose
- Metrics, funnels, experiments
- Dark patterns, and where your line is

You build: a polished showpiece flow and an ethics position.

4 WEEKS 13–16

Design systems

Project: three products, one health-tech company

- Design tokens in three layers
- Components with proper APIs, in Storybook
- Governance, deprecation, adoption

You build: a themed system teams could really adopt.

5 WEEKS 17–20

Capstone & AI interfaces

Project: your pick of four, or your own

- Scope, research, design, test, hand off
- Designing for an AI that is sometimes wrong
- A surprise change, one week before the end

You build: a whole project with no step-by-step help.

6 WEEKS 21–24

Portfolio & interviews

Project: you

- Write case studies people actually read
- Build a live, accessible portfolio
- Practise interviews and whiteboards

You build: three case studies and a site you are proud of.

A taste of the real tasks

Write the error message a candidate sees when a photograph upload fails, in English and Malayalam.

Interview five real people, then find every mistake you made in your own transcript.

Draw a subscription as a state machine: every state, every event, every rule.

Build a cancellation flow that tricks people on purpose, then document the harm.

Reject a teammate's component in a way they actually accept.

Design what an underwriter sees when an AI score is slow, missing or wrong.

Portfolio work starts early. Case study drafts begin in Sprint 1 and a live site goes up by week 12, so Sprint 6 is finishing, not starting.

4 · HOW THE COURSE RUNS

A normal week, and a normal sprint.

The rhythm never changes for 24 weeks. Only the difficulty does.

One week

DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	DAY 5	DAY 6
Learn	Learn	Learn	Learn	Learn	Cohort day
Do	Do	Do	Do	Do	Lab
			Group critique	Defense, in week 4	Shared system, teardown

Learn = a named chapter or video, then a short summary you write. **Do** = a task that uses exactly that.

One sprint (4 weeks)

WEEK 1
Frame
Understand the problem. Build foundations.

WEEK 2
Build
Design the full flow, every state.

WEEK 3
Test + a surprise
Real users. Then the brief changes.

WEEK 4
Ship & defend
Hand-off, then explain it all.

What makes it different

✓ **Three gates**
Every flow must show all its states, pass an accessibility check, and back each claim with evidence. A gate is a checklist, not an opinion.

! **A surprise every sprint**
Something changes mid-project, like a rule or a participant leaving. You write what broke and what you would do earlier next time.

? **A defense at the end**
55 to 90 minutes. You draw from memory, explain trade-offs and say "I don't know yet, here is how I'd find out".

AI **Labs that build real skills**
5 AI labs and 4 prototyping and responsive labs. You learn to check AI instead of trusting it.

What a defense feels like

- "Draw your whole flow from memory. No files open."
- "Why does this error message say that?"
- "Redo it with one rule changed": *no colour*, *screen reader only*, *2G network*, or *one hand in bright sunlight*.

18–22 hrs **a week, roughly three full days.** This is a serious commitment. It is not compatible with a full-time job. If you cannot give the time, it is better to join a later cohort than to fall behind in week 6.

5 · WHERE IT CAN TAKE YOU

Jobs, proof, and honest expectations.

Here is what this course prepares you to apply for, and what it can't promise.

Roles you can apply for

Junior Product Designer · UI / UX Designer · Associate Designer · Junior UX Researcher · Design Systems Associate · Interaction Designer (entry)

Typical places: product startups, software companies, fintech and banks, government-tech, NGOs, design agencies.

Why an employer might pick you

- You can explain **why** you made each decision.
- You know accessibility, and can prove you tested it.
- You have shown evidence, not just screenshots.
- You use AI tools honestly, and can say where they fail.
- You have worked with a team's design system.

What you leave with

- **3 case studies** that include your mistakes
- **A live portfolio**, up by week 12
- **6 defenses** you passed out loud
- **A design system** you helped build
- **3 recorded mock interviews**
- An **outside, honest verdict** on your readiness

Honest note: we cannot promise a job

Junior design hiring is competitive, and results depend on the market, your city, your earlier experience, and how many applications you send. No course can guarantee an offer. Be careful of any that do.

What we do promise: an outside reviewer tells you plainly where you stand (*Ready*, *Ready with a gap*, or *Not yet*). We check in at 30, 90 and 180 days after the course, and we share the real numbers with the next cohort, whatever they are.

6 · IS IT RIGHT FOR ME?

Join if you…

- Can give about 20 hours a week for 24 weeks
- Like working things out, and hearing honest feedback
- Want proof of skill, not just a certificate
- Are happy to start from zero

Wait if you…

- Want a quick course you can finish in a month
- Need a guaranteed job at the end
- Cannot spare weekly time, or have a full-time job
- Prefer watching videos to making things

Ready to start from zero?

Ask the DOTSET team about the next cohort and a short conversation about fit.